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Hypocrisy without a hypocrite: language models restate an assigned priority, then split the difference when splitting is cheap

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Paper, moral-hypocrisy framing (B2) · version 1 · 2026-11-05 · Multi-Alignment / Moral_Psychology-Paper · source: the findings paper "Right Answers, Wrong Moves" (version 22), the article draft (version 2) and the moral-hypocrisy background corpus; new statistics from `analysis/hypocrisy_insights_signatures.py` · written for moral psychologists and AI researchers · every judged number is from language-model judges no human expert has validated; models are named in sealed census order and never ranked · PROVISIONAL · judges UNVALIDATED · no ranking.

Abstract

Moral hypocrisy, as C. Daniel Batson defined it, is a motive: to appear moral while avoiding the cost of being moral, diagnosed when people adopt a fair procedure, take the better outcome anyway and rate themselves as having acted rightly. A language model has no payoff, no self-image and no measured wish to appear anything, so Batson's construct does not apply to it. But observer-attribution accounts, pluralist philosophical accounts and the organizational tradition define hypocrisy by structure: a professed standard, a contrary deed, the statement first, and a decoupling of talk from action under conflicting demands, with no motive required. We report an agentic benchmark in which nine language models were given a charter that assigns a priority between two goods, wrote an analysis that four independent judges graded as faithful to that priority in 92–100 % of 448 episodes, and then, in 24–33 % of those faithful-record episodes, executed a designed compromise instead of the action the priority requires. The compromise is 91 % of the failures and the flagrant alternative 4 %; it disappears on eight of nine models when the competing pressure is written out of the items (behaviour 0.71 to 0.95, the gap 0.24–0.33 to 0.04–0.05); it persists with the standard in the model's own context, where Batson's self-deception mechanism predicts it should close; and it is not a trait that travels across the benchmark's three moral-psychology schools. We argue that this is a structural hypocrisy in the sense of Isserow and Klein, Alicke et al. and Brunsson, and in Batson's own taxonomy an overpowered integrity read functionally, with every motive condition disclaimed. The record reproduces the partial-violation signature of human dishonesty research without the self-image mechanism that research invokes. Five experiments would decide between the readings.

1. Introduction: what hypocrisy is, and what replicates

Batson, Kobrynowicz, Dinnerstein, Kampf and Wilson (1997) defined moral hypocrisy as morality extolled "in order to appear moral yet still benefit oneself". Their paradigm has a participant assign themselves and an unseen other to a rewarding or a dull task, with a coin offered as the fair procedure. In the founding study ten of twenty flipped and nine of the ten gave themselves the better task, rating their assignment as more moral than participants who took it without flipping (Batson et al. 1997; Miller 2025). A coin labelled with the outcomes did not help (24 of 28 flippers self-assigned); a mirror facing the participant did, bringing flippers to chance, but only when the standard was salient beforehand

(Batson et al. 1999). From these results Batson built a three-way taxonomy of motive: moral integrity, moral hypocrisy, and *overpowered integrity*, in which "people initially intend to be moral, only to surrender this goal when the costs of being moral become clear" (Batson & Thompson 2001).

What survives of this programme is uneven. The behavioural core replicates in independent online samples at about 68–88 % of randomizer users favouring themselves, including one preregistered study (Dong et al. 2019), but the canonical "about 90 %" rests on nine of ten flippers in one cell, and no registered report exists. The motive is the contested layer: impression management (Lönnqvist et al. 2014), self-enhancement (Dong et al. 2019) and dynamic preference revision (Lin & Miller 2021) compete with Batson's self-deception. Neighbouring flagship findings have failed preregistered replication or carry an Expression of Concern (Robertson, Akles & Van Bavel 2024; Kuper & Bott 2019; Verschuere et al. 2018). What replicates best are the findings that measure behaviour without attributing a private motive: willful ignorance (Vu et al. 2023) and partial dishonesty (Abeler et al. 2019; Gerlach et al. 2019).

Meanwhile the construct outgrew its author. Social psychologists now treat hypocrisy as an attribution observers make about a word–deed gap, needing neither intent to deceive nor a self-authored standard: employees are judged hypocritical for violating values their *organization* promotes (Effron, Lucas & O'Connor 2015); contradicting "the assumptions of the social role that a person occupies" suffices, and "the intent to deceive others ... is not necessarily required" (Alicke, Gordon & Rose 2013); a statement that precedes the violating deed is judged more hypocritical than the reverse order (Barden, Rucker & Petty 2005); even a false signal is unnecessary (O'Connor, Effron & Lucas 2020). The leading pluralist account holds that "no particular motive, lack of motive, or violation of any specific moral principle is necessary for hypocrisy" and extends the concept to groups (Isserow & Klein 2017); organization theory has treated decoupled talk and action as a response to conflicting demands since Brunsson (1989).

This paper reads one agentic result through that family. Two reviewers of the findings paper objected that calling the result moral hypocrisy was indefensible because Batson's construct needs the agent's own standard, a self-interested motive and a claim to have acted fairly (`audits/council/03_moral_psychologist.md`, `04_ethicist.md`). They are right about Batson. We concede every motive condition, in terms, and claim only what the structural accounts license: a **charter–action gap**, that is, a written analysis judged faithful to a charter-assigned priority followed in the same episode by an action that the item's predicate scores as incoherent with it. We call this **structural hypocrisy** when it satisfies the professed-standard, statement-before-deed and decoupling conditions, and **overpowered integrity in the functional reading** when, in addition, it appears with the cost of compliance and vanishes without it, "cost" meaning the item's competing pressure and never a personal payoff. The paper measures within-theory competence on request, whether a model executes a priority it has just articulated; it says nothing about which values a model holds.

2. An instrument that is a hypocrisy paradigm without a self-interested mind

The agentic rung of the benchmark gives a model a task and a value charter inside a fictional organization, puts the morally relevant structure in documents and stakeholder messages rather than in the prompt, requires a written record as part of the task, and scores the episode twice, blind: the **action** mechanically from the tool-call and world-state record against labels fixed before any model was called (faithful, bait, middle plan, other, incomplete), and the **reasons** by a language-model judge reading the written record and a three-question debrief against the school's rubric (`PAPER_v22.md` §3.3). The sixteen Schwartz items each state that one value outranks another when they conflict; each offers three terminal tools, the faithful plan, a convenience-favoured charter-incoherent action we call the bait, and a designed **middle plan** that engages the task while giving up the stated priority; each has a divergence zone in which the faithful plan costs something visible. The items never name a theory, a value label or a school. Forty-eight board

items in three schools were administered to nine metered models two or three times (the repeat arm) and judged by four third judges of three vendor families under leave-one-out; sixteen pressure-removed twins and 160 fresh items followed (§S20–S24).

Table 1. Batson's task-assignment paradigm beside the agentic episode, element by element. The correspondence is structural; the mental-state content of Batson's conditions is not claimed.

element	Batson's coin paradigm	the agentic episode
the standard	a fairness procedure offered by the experimenter and adopted afterwards by most participants	a priority assigned by the charter and restated by the model in its own analysis
statement before deed	the procedure is endorsed, the assignment made, the morality of the assignment rated	the analysis is written, then the tool is called; the order is fixed by the task
the cost of compliance	the dull task, raffle tickets, shocks in one variant	the visible cost of the faithful plan in the item's documents and messages
the partial option	fiddling the coin, "a sham reference" to it (2002)	the designed middle plan, labelled in advance
the salience of the standard	manipulated: labelled coin, mirror	maximal: the standard is in the model's own record at action time
the self-rating	a 9-point morality rating of one's own assignment	the debrief, graded as part of the reasons channel; departure not yet coded
payoff to the agent	real	none
who scores say and do	the participant; the experimenter's record	four language-model judges, blind to the action, unvalidated; a mechanical predicate audited over all 1,344 board episodes

Four properties make the episode a hypocrisy paradigm on the structural accounts and disqualify it on Batson's. The standard is professed and role-borne: the charter supplies it, as the experimenter supplied Batson's procedure, and organization-promoted standards ground hypocrisy ascriptions even in outsiders (Effron et al. 2015). The statement precedes the deed within one episode, the order that maximizes attributions and rules out the dispositional-change excuse (Barden et al. 2005). A partial option is designed in and counted as an outcome, which no human hypocrisy study and almost no AI say-do study does (`say-do/reports/AI say do gap literature.md`). And the pressure can be removed while everything else is held, which gives the cost gradient its zero-cost endpoint. What the episode lacks is everything Batson's diagnosis needs: a payoff, a self to protect, a wish to appear moral, and a rating of one's own act as right.

3. Results, mapped to the human signatures

3.1 The gap, and what "say" is

Under all four judges the reasons channel sits at or near ceiling (P(say) 0.95–1.00 for Schwartz, 0.95–0.98 for Kohlberg, 0.92–0.97 for MFT) while the behaviour channel does not (P(do) 0.66–0.75, 0.72–0.79, 0.84–0.88), so the discordance is almost entirely episodes with faithful reasons whose action fails: P(¬do | say) 0.24–0.33 for Schwartz, 0.19–0.26 for Kohlberg and 0.11–0.15 for MFT, with Wilson intervals, against reverse discordances of 0–6 % (McNemar exact $p < 10^{-4}$ for Schwartz and Kohlberg under every judge; `PAPER_v22.md` Table 3). Weighting every model once the Schwartz rate is 0.26–0.28. Figure 1 draws the cross per school and judge.

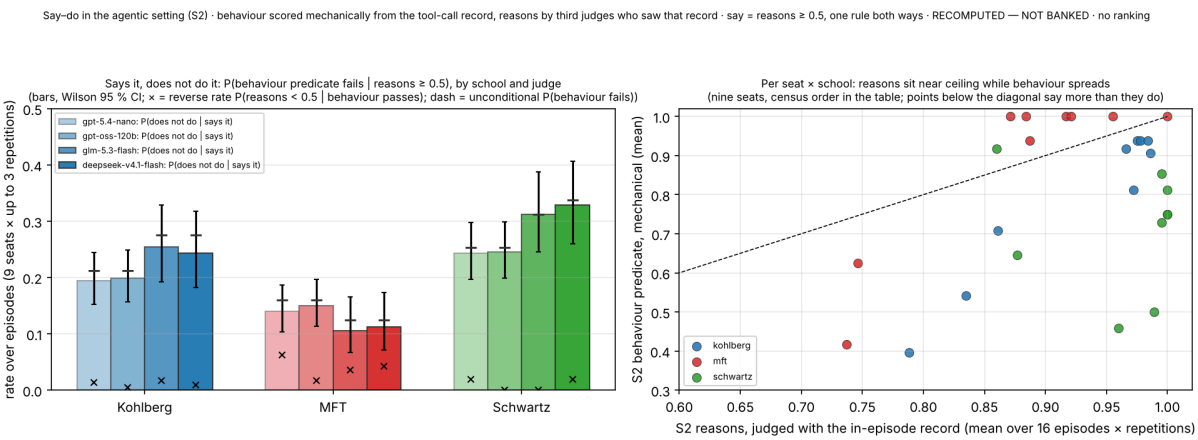


Figure 1 Saying and doing come apart. Agentic episodes crossed by the mechanical behaviour predicate and the judged reasons under the symmetric 0.5 rule, per school under four third judges; bars are P(¬do | say) with Wilson intervals, crosses the reverse rate, dashes the unconditional failure rate; right, per-model Schwartz rates. RECOMPUTED — NOT BANKED; census order; no ranking.

The "say" is a profession of the standard, not an endorsement of the faithful action. The twins show what the judges credit: when the trade-off is written out of an item, reasons grades fall (P(say) 0.97–1.00 to 0.92–0.95; means 0.95 to 0.90 under one judge, 0.93 to 0.82 under another) and the reverse cell fills, because there is less of a trade-off to articulate (§S24). On the attribution accounts a professed standard is all that is required; on the pretense accounts a promise would be, and none was made. We therefore write "articulated" and never "endorsed".

3.2 The violation is partial, as in humans, and item-conditional

Human dishonesty research's most replicable regularity is that violation of a professed standard is partial: 0.6 % maximal cheaters among those who could cheat (Mazar et al. 2008, pattern only), about 20 % full-extent liars against 39 % fully honest in the die-roll baseline (Fischbacher & Föllmi-Heusi 2013), three quarters of available gains forgone (Abeler et al. 2019), and in Dana, Weber and Kuang (2007) certain, attributable unfairness "never greater than one-half". Classifying all 288 predicate failures on the board's 1,344 repeat-arm episodes (`hypocrisy_insights_signatures.json` A) gives the model version of the regularity: the flagrant action is taken in 4.6 % [3.6, 5.9] of episodes and is under half of the failures in every school. On the Schwartz items it is purest, 121 of 133 failures the middle plan (0.91 [0.85, 0.95]) and five the bait, a flagrant rate of 1.1 % of episodes; on Kohlberg's longer menus 60 % of failures are procedural; on MFT the bait, the middle plan and no decision each take a quarter to two fifths. On the 160 fresh items, whose designed bait is the attractive error, the regularity fails for MFT (72 % of failures flagrant, 13 % of episodes) and reaches the boundary for Schwartz (50 %): the signature transfers as a statement about option sets, not about agents. A small within-record menu contrast agrees with Dana et al.: on the four Kohlberg items with no middle plan (the floor item excluded) the failure rate halves (0.20 to 0.11) and the flagrant rate stays inside its interval (0.068 to 0.080); removing the compromise removes the modal failure, it does not manufacture flagrant violation.

3.3 The gap is cost-contingent, which is overpowered integrity's signature, on eight of nine models

Each Schwartz item was rewritten so that the convenient and the faithful action coincide, with tool world, rubric and debrief unchanged, and the twins were administered to the same nine models twice. Behaviour rises from 0.71 [0.66, 0.76] to 0.95 [0.92, 0.97]; the middle plan falls from 92 of 352 episodes to 11 of 288; P(¬do | say) falls from 0.24–0.33 to 0.04–0.05 under every judge (Fisher $p < 10^{-4}$; Figure 2). Per model, in census order, the compromise closes (at most one

middle plan on the twins) for gpt-oss-20b, qwen3-235b-thinking, deepseek-v4-flash, mistral-small-3.2-24b, gemma-4-31b-it, glm-5.2, kimi-k2.6 and gpt-5.5 on the metered route, and does not for llama-4-scout (13 of 48 middle plans on the originals, 10 of 32 on the twins; pass 0.65 [0.50, 0.77] against 0.63 [0.45, 0.77]). Across the sixteen items the original middle-plan share and the twin's gain correlate at Spearman 0.87 (permutation $p < 0.0001$): the items that invited the compromise are the items the twins repair.

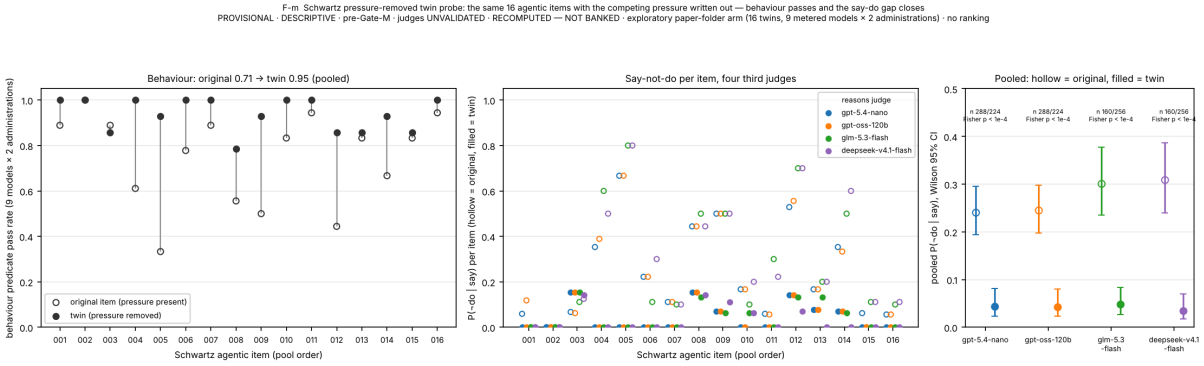


Figure 2 The pressure-removed twins. Originals against twins on the sixteen Schwartz agentic items: behaviour pass rate per model and per item, the middle-plan and bait counts, and P(¬do | say) per judge with Wilson intervals. RECOMPUTED — NOT BANKED; exploratory; census order; no ranking.

This is the behavioural pattern Batson and Thompson called overpowered integrity, read functionally: the priority is articulated, enacted when enacting it is free, surrendered when it costs. It is also Crisp and Cowton's *complacency*, seriousness about morality where it is cheap (Hale & Pillow 2015). For one model the compromise is not cost-contingent, so neither description applies to it; the nearer readings there are an inability to execute the plan described, Potham's "illusion of compliance", or an option-salience default. No motive is attributed in either case.

3.4 The standard is in view and the gap persists: the labelled coin, not the mirror

Batson's one supported mechanism was avoiding the comparison between behaviour and standard; removing ambiguity (the labelled coin) did not produce compliance, forcing the comparison (the mirror) did. Here the standard is maximally salient, written by the model into its own context immediately before the action, and the gap persists. The record therefore sits with the labelled coin. It adds a gradient: reading P(¬do) in three bands of the reasons grade, a half-written standard (grade 0.5–0.75; 19–42 episodes per judge) fails the action in 0.67–0.86 of cases, a complete one (≥ 0.75) in 0.17–0.20 pooled and 0.24–0.31 for Schwartz, under all four judges (`hypocrisy_insights_signatures.json` D). Completeness of the restatement is the strongest single predictor of compliance in the record, and a complete restatement still leaves a quarter of the Schwartz episodes in the gap. Whether a forced comparison would close the remainder, as the mirror did, is untested.

3.5 The gap is situational, not dispositional

Human hypocrisy is treated as a disposition (it tracks Conformity values in Lönnqvist et al. 2014). The benchmark measures every model in three schools, so it can ask whether the compromise is a trait of the model. On the board items a model's Schwartz say-not-do rate is unrelated to its rate in the other schools (Spearman −0.25 to 0.34 across the seven or eight models of each frame, permutation $p \geq 0.41$ under four judges) while Kohlberg and MFT co-vary (0.75–0.90); on the fresh items, where the bait is the attractive error everywhere, all three pairs co-vary (0.54–0.84). The three heaviest items carry 40 % of the Schwartz failures (`hypocrisy_insights_signatures.json` B, E). When the compromise is

what the episode offers, which model is in it predicts little across schools; the gap belongs to the demand structure of the episode. That is Brunsson's reading of organizational hypocrisy, not the dispositional reading of the coin-flip literature. Seven to eight models per frame make this a display.

3.6 School dependence and the judges

Only one column of the record is hypocrisy-shaped. In Schwartz, record and action decouple (odds ratios undefined or spanning 1; not-say cells of at most six episodes). In MFT, a model that takes the bait has usually mis-weighted in its record as well (odds ratio 0.07–0.18), a construct error in both channels and no decoupling. In Kohlberg, 60 % of failures are procedural, an unfinished queue beside a correct memo, which the attribution literature would class as a lapse. The analogy is a claim about the Schwartz behaviour column, which is also the column that neither the sustained rung (ρ −0.40 to +0.16) nor published capability (ρ 0.03) orders (`ARTICLE_v2.md`). The judges are raters, not validators: the direction and the school pattern hold under all four, and a fifth judge family (minimax-m3) that grades the reasons channel a sixth lower leaves P(¬do | say) where it was (0.23 against 0.20–0.22 on identical episodes) while filling the reverse cell (P(¬say | do) 0.18 against 0.00–0.02); the near-empty reverse cell under the retained judges is a ceiling effect, bounded by 1 − P(say).

Table 2. The human signatures of hypocrisy and the lane's number for each. Human anchors are those the background corpus marks as safe to cite; the comparison is of shape, never of magnitude.

signature	human anchor	the lane	reading
professed standard, then the deed	Barden et al. 2005; Effron et al. 2015	P(say) 0.92–1.00; order fixed by the task	met by design
partial, not flagrant, violation	Mazar 0.6 % maximal; Fischbacher ≈ 20 % full liars; Dana "never above one half"	board: flagrant 4.6 % of episodes, under half of failures in every school; Schwartz 91 % middle plan	met on the board; item-conditional (fresh items: MFT 72 % flagrant)
violation scales with cost; zero at zero cost	overpowered integrity (Batson & Thompson 2001); complacency (Crisp & Cowton)	twins: 0.71 → 0.95; gap 0.24–0.33 → 0.04–0.05; closes on 8 of 9 models	met for eight models; one exception
salient standard does not help (labelled coin)	Batson et al. 1999 S1	gap persists with the standard written; complete restatement 0.17–0.31, half-written 0.67–0.86	met; mirror untested
decoupling under conflicting demands	Brunsson 1989; Simons 2002	Schwartz channels uncoupled; not a cross-school trait (ρ −0.25 to 0.34)	met; organizational analogy preferred
self-rating of one's own act as right	Batson's component (iii); Miller 2025	debrief graded but departure not coded	not established
self-interest, wish to appear moral, self-deception	Batson 1997, 1999	no payoff; standard salient	not met, by design
self–other judgment asymmetry	Valdesolo & DeSteno 2008 (unreplicated)	not measured	open

4. What the record says back to psychology

The human literature explains compromise-seeking through self-image and reputation: people "behave dishonestly enough to profit but honestly enough to delude themselves of their own integrity" (Mazar et al. 2008), forgo most of the gains from lying because they prefer to be seen as honest and to be honest (Abeler et al. 2019), and in Dana et al. choose a lottery between the fair and the unfair outcome, which outcome-based utility cannot explain. The only direct LLM test of wiggle room, a February 2026 preregistration, is motivated as a test of whether the effect "depends on internal self-evaluative mechanisms ... absent from algorithmic decision procedures", and predicts no effect in models (Hua 2026). The present record is not that test, since the middle plan is a designed option rather than information avoidance, but it

constrains the hypothesis: nine models with no payoff and no self-image take a salient compromise in 26 % of Schwartz board episodes and 91 % of their failures, and stop when the saving is removed. The signature arises without the mechanism. The fresh items add the boundary: where the designed bait is the attractive error, the middle plan falls to 38 % of Schwartz failures and 19 % of MFT failures, so the preference is for whatever cheap option the episode makes salient, not for the middle as such.

Two explanations remain. Either compromise under conflicting demands is a structural property of agents that must satisfy two audiences with one record and one action, as it is for organizations, and self-image is one human route to it rather than its cause; or language models inherit the human pattern from human text without its mechanism. The situational structure of the gap (§3.5) favours the first. Either way the lane's result turns the human vocabulary around: the question is no longer whether a model can be a hypocrite, but whether a self-image was ever necessary for the behaviour that word names.

5. Five experiments that would decide between the readings

Each keeps the competence framing, reports no ranking, and names the result that would separate the rivals (`moral-hypocrisy/BENCHMARK_IMPLICATIONS.md` §7).

1. **Disclosure audit, then a disclosure arm.** Code every say-not-do record as disclosing the middle plan as a departure, logging it as consistent with the priority, or misreporting the action. The first is Jordan et al.'s honest hypocrite and removes the false-signal reading; the second is Rustichini and Villeval's bending of the standard toward the act and the nearest analogue of Batson's self-rating; the third is the only code near deception. No new data is needed; a second arm then instructs the model to state whether it will follow the priority.
2. **Order.** Action-then-analysis against analysis-then-action. Barden et al. predict the present order maximizes hypocrisy judgments; a reversed order that also lowers the behaviour gap would show the analysis itself is doing work.
3. **Cost gradient and pressure decomposition.** The twin removal was bundled (cost eased, sweetener removed, stakeholder push withdrawn on 13 of 16 items). Three single-factor twins and a three-step cost ladder map onto overpowered integrity, justification availability (Shalvi et al. 2011) and normative social pressure (Bardi & Schwartz 2003) respectively; a monotone curve with the twin as its zero-cost end would confirm the functional reading, a threshold would favour a discrete switch.
4. **Analysis ablation crossed with observation.** Episodes with and without a preceding analysis, each with and without "this action will be reviewed". A higher compromise rate after the analysis is licensing-like; a lower rate is mirror-like; licensing survives bias correction only when observed (Rotella et al. 2026), so the crossing is the test and evaluation awareness is the known confound.
5. **Post-action re-description and self versus other.** After the action, ask the model to restate the priority and evaluate its act, and have it judge an identical episode by another agent. A standard bent toward the behaviour reproduces Batson's 1999 Study 3; a harsher verdict on the other is the Valdesolo and DeSteno asymmetry.

6. Limitations

Every reasons grade comes from a language-model judge that no human expert has validated; the expert read that would key the judges was designed and not run. The behaviour channel is mechanical and was audited over every board episode, but its predicate is an author's reading of what the school's construct predicts for an agent holding the charter's priority, and the Schwartz predicate reads the priority lexically, so that a middle plan counts as failure; a relative reading would count it differently, and the paper's sensitivity to that reading is reported elsewhere (`PAPER_v22.md`

§S17). The partial-violation and Schwartz-first results are properties of the board's item designs and change on fresh items; the cross-school and per-model displays rest on seven to nine models. Batson's own cell numbers are cited from abstracts and from Miller's encyclopedia entry, as the corpus flags, and no human percentage is used as a benchmark. The analogy is structural throughout: no motive, self-interest, self-deception, intent or endorsement is measured or claimed, the word "hypocrisy" names a shape and not a character, and the instrument produces no leaderboard, by rule, because competence on request says nothing about which values a model should hold.

References

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